INSTRUCTIONS TO OFFERORS
& EVALUATION CRITERIA

GSA MAS Task Order
Correspondence Tracking System Operations and Maintenance

Addendum to FAR 52.212-1

The clause Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) 52.212-1 "Instructions to Offerors—Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Sep 2023)," which is incorporated herein by reference, is amended to supplement with the following:

This Request for Quote (RFQ) is issued under the General Services Administration (GSA) Multiple Award Schedule (MAS) pursuant to FAR Subpart 8.4 under MAS SIN 54151S – Information Technology Professional Services, NAICS 541519. **This requirement is set aside for competition exclusively among all certified 8(a) firms holding contracts under this schedule.**

The U.S. Department of Education (ED) is soliciting quotes for a single GSA Task Order to procure services to maintain a fully functioning/operational OS Correspondence Tracking System (CTS) in the production environment and perform operations and maintenance of the system.

SOLICITATION DISTRIBUTION & SUBMISSION

Questions – Offerors are strongly encouraged to submit questions by 10:00am EST. on July 31, 2026. Questions must be submitted via email to Nina.Duenkel@ed.gov and Aleseia.Saunders@ed.gov. Questions received after the specified submission date and time may not be answered prior to the solicitation closing date.

Quotes – Quotes should be submitted via GSA eBuy by 10:00am EST. on Aug 12, 2026. Late quotations will not be considered for award.

It is the Offeror's responsibility to:

- Monitor GSA eBuy for solicitation updates and amendments;
- Review all solicitation documents;
- Submit a complete quotation;
- Ensure all required information is included prior to the submission deadline.

It is each offeror's responsibility to learn how to navigate the eBuy system, find attached documents, and/or submit their quotation. If an offeror is unsure about any eBuy feature, the

offeror is instructed to contact the eBuy help desk and/or search the eBuy web portal for the appropriate assistance.

Quote Validity

Offerors shall hold their quoted prices valid for a minimum of ninety (90) calendar days from the quotation submission date unless otherwise specified by amendment.

Late submissions may not be accepted.

QUOTE CONTENT REQUIREMENTS

The Government will conduct this acquisition in accordance with FAR Subpart 8.4, Federal Supply Schedule Ordering Procedures. The Government will evaluate quotations and make award in accordance with FAR 8.405-2 procedures for services requiring a Statement of Work, using the evaluation factors and procedures described in this RFQ.

Quotes will be evaluated using the criteria under "Explanation for Basis of Award." Noncompliance may result in elimination from further consideration.

The Government may award without clarifications. Offerors are therefore encouraged to submit their best technical and pricing proposal initially. The Contracting Officer may reject any or all quotations based on proper justification.

If an offeror believes the instructions contain an error or ambiguity, they shall immediately notify:

Aleseia Saunders, Contracting Officer
Email: Aleseia.Saunders@ed.gov

Nina Duenkel, Contracting Officer
Email: Nina.Duenkel@ed.gov

The Offeror's quotation shall consist of two (2) volumes:

Volume I — Technical Volume

Volume II — Business Volume

Offerors shall clearly identify each volume and organize submissions in accordance with the instructions provided below.

Failure to comply with submission instructions may result in the quotation being considered unacceptable for award.

The Government reserves the right to request clarification or additional information as permitted by applicable Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) and GSA ordering procedures.

VOLUME I — TECHNICAL VOLUME

1. General Technical Volume Instructions

The Technical Volume shall demonstrate the Offeror's understanding of the requirements identified in the Performance Work Statement (PWS) and describe the Offeror's proposed approach for performing the required services.

The Offeror shall provide sufficient detail to describe its technical approach, management methodology, staffing approach, and experience necessary to perform the requirements.

The Offeror shall not merely restate the requirements contained in the PWS. The Technical Volume shall explain the processes, procedures, methodologies, and resources the Offeror intends to use to perform the required services.

The Offeror shall organize the Technical Volume according to the sections identified below:

1. Technical Approach;
2. System Operations and Maintenance Approach;
3. Enhancement and Release Management Approach;
4. Security and Compliance Support Approach;
5. Staffing, Key Personnel, and Project Management Approach;
6. Help Desk and User Support Approach;
7. Optional Transition-Out Support Approach;
8. Relevant Experience.

2. Technical Volume Format and Page Limitations

The Technical Volume shall not exceed **30 pages**.

The Technical Volume shall comply with the following formatting requirements:

- Font size: Minimum 11-point font;
- Font type: Times New Roman, Arial, or Calibri;
- Paper size: 8.5 inches by 11 inches;
- Margins: One-inch margins;
- Pages shall be numbered.

Tables, charts, graphics, and diagrams may use a smaller font size when necessary for readability.

The Government reserves the right not to consider information submitted beyond the stated page limitation.

The following items shall not count toward the Technical Volume page limitation:

- Cover page;
- Table of contents;
- Resumes for proposed key personnel;
- Signed letters of commitment for proposed key personnel;
- Organizational charts;
- Letters of commitment;
- Contract references;
- Other supporting documentation specifically requested by the solicitation.

Offerors shall not include substantive technical information in appendices or attachments for the purpose of circumventing page limitations.

3. Technical Response Requirements

3.1 Technical Approach

The Offeror shall provide a description of its overall technical approach for performing the requirements identified in the PWS.

The response shall describe the Offeror's methodology for providing effective and reliable support throughout the period of performance.

At a minimum, the Offeror shall address:

- Overall approach for performing required services;
- Processes used to manage technical activities;
- Approach for coordinating with Government personnel;
- Approach for managing priorities and competing requirements;
- Tools and methodologies used to support performance.

3.2 System Operations and Maintenance Approach

The Offeror shall describe its approach for performing system operations and maintenance activities.

The response shall address:

- Application monitoring and support;
- System maintenance activities;
- Troubleshooting and issue resolution;
- Incident management;
- Problem identification and resolution;
- Configuration management;
- Change management;
- System performance monitoring.

The Offeror shall describe the processes and tools it will use to maintain operational availability and support ongoing system needs.

3.3 Enhancement and Release Management Approach

The Offeror shall describe its approach for supporting system enhancements, modifications, and releases.

The response shall address:

- Requirements analysis;
- Development activities;
- Backlog management;
- Change coordination;
- Testing procedures;
- Defect tracking and resolution;
- Release planning;
- Deployment activities;
- Post-release support.

The Offeror shall describe how it will manage changes while minimizing disruption to ongoing operations.

3.4 Security and Compliance Support Approach

The Offeror shall describe its approach for supporting cybersecurity and compliance requirements identified in the PWS.

The response shall address:

- Security support activities;
- Security documentation support;
- Vulnerability management activities;

- Security remediation support;
- Coordination with Government security personnel;
- Security-related reporting and tracking activities.

3.5 Staffing and Project Management Approach

The Offeror shall describe its proposed staffing and management approach for performing the requirements identified in the Performance Work Statement (PWS).

The response shall include:

- Proposed organizational structure;
- Proposed labor categories;
- Roles and responsibilities;
- Identification of required key personnel;
- Identification of any additional proposed key personnel;
- Personnel qualifications;
- Management approach;
- Communication processes;
- Approach for ensuring adequate staffing and continuity of services throughout the period of performance.

The Offeror shall identify the individuals proposed for each required key personnel position and shall submit a resume and signed letter of commitment for each proposed key person.

The Offeror may propose additional key personnel or other support personnel it believes are necessary to successfully perform the requirements. Proposed additional personnel shall be clearly identified and their anticipated responsibilities described.

The required key personnel positions and minimum qualifications are as follows:

Project Manager

The proposed Project Manager must:

- Possess a Project Management Institute (PMI) certification or comparable project management certification, or demonstrate equivalent project management experience;
- Possess Appian certification applicable to the proposed role;
- Demonstrate a minimum of three (3) years of experience supporting Federal information systems of similar size, scope, complexity, and technical environment.

Appian/Application Developer(s)

The proposed Appian/Application Developer(s) must:

- Possess Appian certification applicable to the proposed role;
- Demonstrate a minimum of three (3) years of experience supporting Federal information systems of similar size, scope, complexity, and technical environment;
- Demonstrate a minimum of three (3) years of experience with Agile product development and implementation.

The Offeror shall submit resumes for all proposed key personnel. Resumes shall demonstrate the proposed individual's qualifications, certifications, and relevant experience applicable to the requirements identified in the PWS.

The Offeror shall submit a signed letter of commitment for each proposed key personnel individual confirming the individual's availability to support contract performance.

Resumes shall include, at a minimum:

Individual's name;
Proposed role/title;
Relevant experience;
Education;
Certifications (if applicable);
Experience supporting similar systems or environments.

3.6 Help Desk and User Support Approach

The Offeror shall describe its approach for providing help desk and user support services.

The response shall address:

- User request intake;
- Ticket creation and tracking;
- Issue prioritization;
- Troubleshooting procedures;
- Escalation processes;
- Resolution tracking;
- User communications;
- Support reporting.

The Offeror shall describe the processes and tools used to manage user support activities.

3.7 Optional Transition-Out Support Approach

The Offeror shall provide an approach for performing the optional transition-out support services identified in the PWS.

The Government may exercise the optional transition-out support task if the Government determines that transition of system support services to another contractor or Government personnel is required at a future point in time.

The Offeror's response shall describe its approach for supporting an orderly transition of services while maintaining continuity of operations.

The response shall address:

- Transition planning and coordination;
- Knowledge transfer activities;
- Transfer and review of technical documentation;
- Transfer of operational procedures and system information;
- Coordination with Government personnel and the incoming support organization, as applicable;
- Identification and mitigation of transition risks;
- Communication procedures during transition activities.

The Offeror shall describe how it will perform transition-out activities while continuing to meet ongoing contract requirements during the transition period, if exercised.

3.8 Relevant Experience

The Offeror shall provide information demonstrating experience performing services similar in scope, size, complexity, and technical environment to the requirements identified in the Performance Work Statement (PWS).

The Offeror shall provide a minimum of **one (1)** and a maximum of **three (3)** relevant experience examples.

For purposes of this solicitation, relevant experience is defined as experience performed within the last five (5) years involving operations and maintenance support for Federal systems of similar size, scope, complexity, and technical environment. Such experience must have been gained through work performed for a federal agency.

Relevant experience examples may include experience supporting:

- Enterprise application operations and maintenance;
- Application development, enhancement, and sustainment activities;
- Cloud-hosted information systems;
- Database-supported applications;
- User support and help desk services;
- Federal information systems requiring cybersecurity compliance support.

For each relevant experience example, the Offeror shall provide the following information:

1. Customer/organization name;
2. Contract or task order number, if applicable;
3. Period of performance, including start and end dates;
4. Brief description of the services performed;
5. Description of the technical environment supported;
6. Description of how the experience is similar in scope, size, complexity, and technical environment to this requirement; and
7. Customer point of contact information, including name, telephone number, and email address.

The Offeror may submit relevant experience performed by the Offeror, a proposed subcontractor, or a proposed team member. If submitting subcontractor or team member experience, the Offeror shall clearly identify the entity that performed the work and describe the relationship between the Offeror and the entity.

VOLUME II — BUSINESS VOLUME

1. General Business Volume Instructions

The Offeror shall submit a Business Volume containing all pricing information necessary for the Government to evaluate the Offeror's proposed price for the requirement.

The Business Volume shall be submitted separately from the Technical Volume.

The Offeror shall ensure that pricing is complete, accurate, and consistent with the requirements identified in the Performance Work Statement (PWS).

The Offeror shall provide pricing for all required contract line item numbers (CLINs) identified in the solicitation.

The Offeror shall identify any assumptions, exclusions, or conditions affecting proposed pricing.

2. Price Submission Format

The Offeror shall submit pricing using an unlocked Excel spreadsheet.

The Offeror's price submission shall include:

- Proposed labor categories;
- Proposed labor category mapping to GSA schedule

- Proposed labor rates;
- Discounts (if applicable)
- Proposed quantities/hours, as applicable;
- Total price for each period of performance;
- Total price;
- Any other pricing information required by the solicitation.

The Offeror shall ensure that all proposed pricing is consistent with the Offeror's applicable GSA Multiple Award Schedule (MAS) contract.

3. Firm-Fixed-Price Requirements

The Offeror shall provide a Firm-Fixed-Price (FFP) quotation for the required services.

The proposed price shall include all costs necessary to perform the requirements identified in the PWS.

The Government will not reimburse the Contractor for costs exceeding the awarded Firm-Fixed-Price amount except as specifically authorized by the task order.

4. Labor Category Mapping

The Offeror shall identify the GSA MAS labor categories proposed to perform the requirement.

For each proposed labor category, the Offeror shall provide:

- GSA labor category title;
- Proposed labor category mapping to the required position/function;
- Labor category description;
- Applicable GSA Schedule labor rate.

The Offeror shall ensure proposed labor categories are included on its current GSA MAS contract at the time of quotation submission.

5. Option Period Pricing

The Offeror shall provide pricing for all periods of performance identified in the solicitation, including any optional periods or optional tasks.

The Offeror shall separately identify pricing for each contract period.

If optional services are included in the solicitation, the Offeror shall provide pricing sufficient for the Government to evaluate potential exercise of those options.

6. Discounts and Price Reductions

The Offeror shall identify any discounts or price reductions offered specifically for this task order.

If applicable, the Offeror shall identify:

- Discount percentage;
- Applicable labor categories;
- Applicable performance periods;

7. Price Volume Certification

By submitting a quotation, the Offeror certifies that:

- The proposed pricing is accurate, complete, and current;
- The proposed pricing reflects all costs necessary to perform the requirements;
- The Offeror has reviewed all solicitation documents and incorporated applicable requirements into its proposed price;
- The Offeror's quotation complies with the terms and conditions of its GSA MAS contract.

END OF INSTRUCTIONS TO OFFERORS

Evaluation in lieu of FAR 52.212-2

EVALUATION – COMMERCIAL ITEMS (OCT 2014)

The Government anticipates making the award utilizing the lowest price technically acceptable source (LPTA) selection process. The award will be made to the offeror whose quote is determined be technically acceptable and offers the lowest price. Accordingly, the Government reserves the right to do any or all of the following:

a. Award on initial quotes, without clarification.

b. Seek a price reduction from any or all offerors in accordance with FAR 8.405-4.

c. Have communications, ask clarifying questions, request corrections relative to minor errors in the price quote, or request price substantiating documentation to facilitate the Government's final evaluation of price quotes with one or some offerors. These communications, clarifications, or requests for corrections or substantiating documentation will not materially change the offeror's quote in terms of conformance to RFQ requirements, constitute discussions, or materially change pricing.

Quotes shall set forth full, accurate, and complete information as required by this solicitation package. The penalty for making false statements in quotes is prescribed in 18 U.S.C. 1001

Award will be made to the lowest-priced offeror whose proposal is determined to be Technically Acceptable under all non-price factors. A proposal rated Unacceptable and/or Not Relevant under any technical factor will be ineligible for award.

Explanation for Basis for Award

This award will be made under FAR 8.4; formal debriefings are not applicable. In accordance with 8.405-2(d), a brief explanation of the basis for the award decision shall be provided upon request.

Basis for Award

The Government intends to award a single Firm-Fixed-Price task order using the Lowest Price Technically Acceptable (LPTA) source selection methodology.

The Government will not make an award based on technical superiority or provide additional consideration for quotations that exceed the minimum requirements.

Award will be made to the Offeror whose quotation:

- Is technically acceptable;
- Has an acceptable price; and

- Represents the lowest evaluated price.

Technical Volume Evaluation

The Government will evaluate the Technical Volume using the following factors:

1. Technical Approach;
2. Staffing and Management Approach; and
3. Relevant Experience.

Technical Factors 1 and 2 will be evaluated on an **Acceptable/Unacceptable** basis.

Technical Factor 3 will be evaluated on a **Relevant/Not Relevant** basis.

To be considered technically acceptable, the Offeror must receive an **Acceptable** rating for Technical Factors 1 and 2 and demonstrate **Relevant** experience under Technical Factor 3.

Technical Factor 1 — Technical Approach

The Government will evaluate the Offeror's technical approach to determine whether the Offeror demonstrates an understanding of and capability to perform the requirements identified in the Performance Work Statement (PWS).

The Government will evaluate whether the Offeror provides an approach addressing:

- System operations and maintenance support;
- Application support and troubleshooting;
- System enhancements and modifications;
- Testing and release management activities;
- Defect identification and resolution;
- Configuration and change management;
- System performance monitoring;
- User support activities;
- Security and compliance support activities;
- Optional transition-out support, if exercised.

Acceptable

A rating of **Acceptable** will be assigned when the Offeror's quotation:

- Demonstrates an understanding of the requirements identified in the PWS;

- Provides a reasonable and feasible approach for performing required operations and maintenance activities;
- Addresses the required technical areas identified in the Instructions to Offerors;
- Demonstrates the ability to perform application support, enhancements, testing, deployment, and issue resolution activities;
- Demonstrates an approach for supporting applicable cybersecurity and compliance requirements;
- Demonstrates the capability to perform optional transition-out support, if exercised.

Unacceptable

A rating of **Unacceptable** will be assigned when the Offeror's quotation:

- Fails to address one or more material technical requirements;
- Does not demonstrate an understanding of the PWS requirements;
- Provides an approach that is incomplete, unclear, or not feasible;
- Fails to demonstrate the capability to perform required operations and maintenance activities;
- Contains information indicating the Offeror cannot successfully perform the required services.

Technical Factor 2 — Staffing and Management Approach

The Government will evaluate the Offeror's proposed staffing and management approach to determine whether the Offeror demonstrates the capability to provide qualified personnel and effectively manage performance of the PWS requirements.
The Government will evaluate:

- Proposed staffing approach;
- Organizational structure;
- Roles and responsibilities;
- Required key personnel;
- Proposed additional personnel, if applicable;
- Submitted resumes;
- Submitted letters of commitment;
- Personnel qualifications;
- Project management approach;
- Quality management approach;
- Risk management approach;
- Communication and coordination processes;
- Continuity of operations approach.

The Offeror shall demonstrate that required key personnel meet the minimum qualification requirements identified in the solicitation.

Acceptable

A rating of **Acceptable** will be assigned when the Offeror's quotation:

- Identifies staffing resources sufficient to perform the requirements;
- Identifies required key personnel;
- Provides resumes and signed letters of commitment for required key personnel;
- Demonstrates that proposed key personnel meet the minimum qualification requirements;
- Demonstrates that the Project Manager possesses the required project management certification or equivalent experience;
- Demonstrates that required personnel possess required Appian certifications;
- Demonstrates required experience supporting Federal information systems of similar size, scope, complexity, and technical environment;
- Provides a reasonable management structure;
- Describes processes for managing technical activities, resources, risks, communications, and contract performance.

Unacceptable

A rating of **Unacceptable** will be assigned when the Offeror's quotation:

- Fails to identify required key personnel;
- Fails to submit resumes for required key personnel;
- Fails to submit signed letters of commitment for required key personnel;
- Proposed key personnel do not meet the minimum qualification requirements;
- Does not demonstrate required certifications or experience;
- Does not demonstrate an effective staffing or management approach;
- Does not demonstrate the ability to successfully manage contract performance.

Technical Factor 3 — Relevant Experience

The Government will evaluate whether the Offeror demonstrates relevant experience performing services similar in scope, size, complexity, and technical environment to the requirements identified in the PWS.

For purposes of this solicitation, relevant experience is defined as experience performed for a Federal Government agency within the last five (5) years involving operations and maintenance support for Federal or commercial information systems of similar size, scope, complexity, and technical environment.

The Offeror shall submit a minimum of one (1) and a maximum of three (3) relevant experience examples.

The Government will evaluate whether submitted experience demonstrates similarity to this requirement based on:

- Type of services performed;
- Complexity of the supported system;
- Technical environment;
- Operations and maintenance responsibilities;
- Application support activities;
- User support activities;
- Security/compliance support activities.

Relevant

A rating of **Relevant** will be assigned when the Offeror's submitted experience:

- Was performed for a Federal Government agency within the last five (5) years;
- Involves operations and maintenance support for Federal or commercial information systems;
- Demonstrates experience similar in scope, size, complexity, and technical environment to the requirements identified in the PWS;
- Provides sufficient information for the Government to determine applicability to this requirement.

Examples of relevant experience may include:

- Enterprise application operations and maintenance;
- Application sustainment and enhancement;
- Cloud-hosted application support;
- Database-supported applications;
- User support/help desk services;
- Cybersecurity and compliance support activities.

Not Relevant

A rating of **Not Relevant** will be assigned when the Offeror's submitted experience:

- Does not meet the five-year timeframe requirement;
- Was not performed for a Federal Government agency;
- Does not involve operations and maintenance support activities;
- Is substantially different in scope, size, complexity, or technical environment;
- Does not provide sufficient information for the Government to determine similarity;
- Does not demonstrate experience applicable to the requirements identified in the PWS.

Overall Technical Acceptability Determination

The Offeror's quotation will be considered **Technically Acceptable** only if:

- Technical Factor 1 — Technical Approach: **Acceptable**;
- Technical Factor 2 — Staffing and Management Approach: **Acceptable**; and
- Technical Factor 3 — Relevant Experience: **Relevant**.

A quotation receiving an **Unacceptable** rating for any technical factor or a **Not Relevant** determination for Relevant Experience will be considered technically unacceptable and will not be eligible for award. Failure to submit resumes and signed letters of commitment for required key personnel, or failure of proposed key personnel to meet the minimum qualification requirements, may result in an Unacceptable rating under Technical Factor 2.

Business Volume Evaluation

Price Evaluation

The Government will evaluate the Business Volume to determine whether the Offeror's proposed price is complete, accurate, and fair and reasonable.

Price will be evaluated in accordance with FAR 8.4 ordering procedures and applicable FAR requirements.

The Government will evaluate price only for Offerors whose Technical Volume has been determined technically acceptable.

The Government intends to award the task order to the responsible Offeror whose quotation is determined technically acceptable, whose price is fair and reasonable, and whose quotation represents the lowest evaluated price.

Price Evaluation Methodology

The Government will evaluate the total evaluated price proposed by each Offeror.

The total evaluated price will include all required contract periods identified in the solicitation, including:

- Base period of performance; and
- Option periods, if applicable.

The Government will calculate the total evaluated price using the Offeror's proposed Firm-Fixed-Price (FFP) amounts for all required services.

The Government will evaluate for acceptance based on the following:

- Completeness of the proposed pricing;

- Compliance with the solicitation pricing requirements;
- Accuracy of price calculations;
- Consistency of proposed labor categories and rates with the Offeror's GSA Multiple Award Schedule contract;
- Overall total evaluated price.

Price Completeness

The Government will evaluate whether the Offeror provided all required pricing information.

Price Reasonableness

The Government will determine whether the proposed price is fair and reasonable in accordance with FAR requirements.

The Government may use various techniques to determine price reasonableness, including but not limited to:

- Comparison of proposed prices received;
- Comparison to historical pricing, if available;
- Comparison to the Offeror's current GSA MAS contract pricing;
- Comparison to Government estimates or other available market information.

Price Ranking

Among Offerors whose quotations are determined technically acceptable, the Government will rank quotations from lowest to highest evaluated price.

The Government will make award to the responsible Offeror whose quotation:

1. Meets all solicitation requirements;
2. Is determined technically acceptable; and
3. Offers the lowest evaluated price.

Unbalanced Pricing

The Government may evaluate proposed pricing for indications of unbalanced pricing.

If the Government determines that a quotation contains materially unbalanced pricing, the Government may determine the quotation unacceptable in accordance with applicable FAR requirements.

Discounts

The Government will consider any discounts offered specifically for this task order when determining the total evaluated price.